IF I AM STAYING

My change plan

Four days a week in the same job, with Friday outdoors, and two evenings a week that end at six.

In place by the fourth month.

WHAT I KEEP

My job and the people in it, the flat, my sister ten minutes away, and the Thursday market.

THE SMALL TEST I RUN FIRST

Four weeks of evenings that end at six, and one unpaid Friday, before I ask for anything.

1

FIRST WEEK

Ask my manager for a meeting

What must be true first: A month of figures I believe

2

FIRST MONTH

Live on four-fifths pay on paper

What must be true first: Last three months of spending in front of me

3

SECOND MONTH

Put the request in writing

What must be true first: A yes in principle

4

THIRD MONTH

Take a corner of a neighbour's allotment

What must be true first: Tools and boots

5

FOURTH MONTH

First Friday outdoors

What must be true first: The change in place

IF I AM STAYING

What it rests on, and the way back

MONEY AND BUFFER

€2,360 a month from the fourth month, confirmed, against €2,210 of costs. The buffer stays at €6,600, three months of everything, untouched.

HOURS I DECIDE, BEFORE AND AFTER

About 16 hours a week now. About 26 after the change.

WHO I TELL

My sister first, then my manager, then the team. From my sister I need a standing Friday, so somebody is expecting me.

MY FIRST 90 DAYS

Week one, the meeting. After 30 days, two evenings a week that really end at six. After 90 days, the request agreed and in writing.

WHAT IS STILL UNCERTAIN

What the lower pay does to my pension over ten years. Whether I keep the Friday in January, when it is dark and wet.

MY PLAN B

If four days is refused, I keep the two evenings and ask again after six months, with one unpaid day a month meanwhile. If the lower pay does not add up, I go back to five days for a season rather than spend the reserve.

I look at this again: the third month after the change, and again after a year. Staying is a decision like any other, and this is the plan that goes with it.